Khalistan and simultaneously support Bhindranwale. The hope was that by doing so the demand for Khalistan would gradually stick to Bhindranwale, as he would neither contradict nor counter it.

The radical Sikh organization that was thus floated soon after the 13 April 1978 attack on the Nirankari convention was called the Dal Khalsa, 'army of the pure'. Its first meeting was held at Chandigarh in Hotel Aroma, and the bill of Rs 600 was paid by Zail Singh. [4] According to Kuldip Nayar, 'The inaugural function of the organisation pledged in a resolution "to preserve and keep alive the concept of the distinct and independent identity of the 'Sikh Panth'". The political goal spelt out was the "pre-eminence of the Khalsa". ' [5]

In his 2016 book, *Bloodshed in Punjab: Untold Saga of Deceit and Sabotage* , senior journalist G.S. Chawla wrote,

> The president-elect of Dal Khalsa had earlier worked as a stenographer with a former Congress MP from Chandigarh. In a press conference held in Gurudwara Akal Garh, Sector 35 Chandigarh, on August 6, 1978, it was announced that the main objective of setting up Dal Khalsa was to secure the establishment of an independent Sikh state. Next day many Punjab newspapers had published reports that the bill for the expenses at the press conference was also paid by Punjab Congress leaders. [6]

The Dal Khalsa continued to enjoy the patronage of Zail Singh, who became home minister at the Centre in January 1980, and thereafter president of India in July 1982. He would reportedly ring up journalists from Chandigarh and ask them to publish news related to the Dal Khalsa on the front pages of their newspapers. Satish Jacob and Mark Tully wrote in their 2006 book, *Amritsar: Mrs Gandhi's Last Battle,* 'Bhindranwale was never openly associated with the Dal Khalsa. Until his death he maintained that he was a man of religion, not a politician; but the Dal Khalsa was always known as Bhindranwale's party.' [7]